

Are They Still Bringing You the *Real* Problems?

Four checks to see whether your team escalates to you or quietly routes around you — plus the exact repair that brings the messy drafts back.

NAME

DATE

ROLE / TEAM

1

Run the Tense Test on This Week's Messages

- Pull your last **10–15 questions** from Slack or email. Mark each one *future/conditional* ("Should we cut it this way?") or *past tense* ("We went with X, FYI").
- Count the ratio. More than half past tense means you're being **informed, not consulted**.
- Take one past-tense message and rewrite the *future-tense version* it should have been.
- Check this week's meeting invites: were you added while the analysis was **still open**, or after it hit the deck?

TENSE RATIO NOTES

2

Audit the Last Five 'Small' Problems Someone Brought You

- List the last **five small asks** someone brought you. Note the response time and tone for each.
- Did the person ever learn *how it got resolved* — or did it disappear into your queue?
- Look for a **small question testing a bigger one** — like the date-filter ask that was really about the quarterly review.
- Name one ask you answered too fast. What would a *slower, more curious* reply have looked like?

FIVE ASKS LOG

3

Check Your Own Mechanism

- Recall the last rough draft someone brought you. Did you **ask questions first**, or start *fixing mid-sentence*?
- Do you ever open with "**good catch, thanks**" — or does your first line sound like a *cross-examination*?
- Think of the colleague who says "sorry, I know you're busy, but—". What has your pattern **taught them** it costs?
- Write your actual opening line from last time. Would you want to *hear it* if you were them?

OPENING-LINE NOTES

4

Do the Repair (No Announcement)

- Ask two or three people directly: "*What did I do last time that made it not worth bringing me something half-finished?*"
- Next rough problem: commit to **asking questions for ten minutes** before offering a fix. Write down what you asked.
- Define your own *"drafts get rougher"* metric — what would earlier, messier work look like from them?
- Name the **one problem** you're currently being routed around on. What's the ten-foot walk to fix it?

REPAIR COMMITMENTS